

St Dunstan & St Paul's - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

St Dunstan in the East: Layers of Catastrophe

St Dunstan-in-the-East compresses nine hundred years of London's disasters into one small garden. The church dates from around 1100. The Great Fire of 1666 badly damaged it, and rather than a full rebuild, the parish patched the medieval fabric and commissioned Christopher Wren for a new tower and steeple, completed in 1701 — a needle spire carried on four flying buttresses, a Gothic gesture from the great classicist, and structurally audacious enough that contemporaries doubted it. The doubters got their answer twice: it survived the great storm damage that hit other London steeples, and then survived the Blitz. On the night raids of 1941 the church was gutted — one of many Wren-associated churches lost or ruined; of the City's pre-war churches, a substantial fraction never returned to use. The City's decision in 1967 not to rebuild but to plant a public garden in the ruin, opened in 1971, was quietly radical: an official acknowledgment that a ruin could be kept as a ruin, memory as amenity. Today it's a Grade One listed structure where winter-flowering clematis and ornamental vines pour through Gothic tracery. As you walk on toward St Paul's, you're tracing the fire path of 1666 in reverse — nearly everything around you has burned at least once.

Dunstan: Blacksmith, Kingmaker, Saint

It is worth knowing whose name this garden carries, because Dunstan was one of the towering figures of Anglo-Saxon England. Born around nine hundred and nine near Glastonbury, he was that rare thing, a first-rate craftsman and a first-rate politician at once. He worked as a metalsmith and manuscript illuminator, made church plate with his own hands, and was reputedly a fine harpist, which is partly why he became the patron saint of goldsmiths, silversmiths, blacksmiths and musicians. The metalworking guilds adopted him with real affection, and his image, tongs in hand, hung over English forges for centuries.

The tongs come from the legend everyone remembers. The Devil, so the story goes, appeared at Dunstan's workshop to tempt him, shifting shape from old man to boy to seductress. Dunstan let his tongs sit in the fire until they glowed, then seized the fiend by the nose, and the Devil fled shrieking. It is a wonderful piece of eleventh-century folklore, and you should take it in that spirit, but it captures something true about how he was remembered: cunning, unshakeable, a match for anyone, human or otherwise.

His real career was extraordinary. He became Abbot of Glastonbury and reformed English monastic life along strict Benedictine lines, then Bishop of Worcester, Bishop of London, and from nine hundred and fifty-nine, Archbishop of Canterbury. He served as counsellor to a whole succession of kings, was driven into exile at least once when he fell out of royal favour, and came back to dominate the English church. He is generally credited with shaping the coronation service, the *ordo*, elements of which have echoed down through every English coronation since, including the most recent one you may have watched on television.

For nearly two centuries after his death in nine hundred and eighty-eight, Dunstan was the most popular saint in England, more venerated than almost anyone, until the cults of Becket and others eventually eclipsed him.

A quick note on the name, because it puzzles visitors. There are two medieval Dunstan churches in the City, and the tags “in the East” and “in the West” simply tell them apart. St Dunstan in the West still stands on Fleet Street. This one, in the East, sat close to the river in the old wine and fish quarter, which is why you find it tucked below the modern street level. The direction has nothing to do with the saint and everything to do with a medieval Londoner needing to know which Dunstan you meant when you named it as a meeting place.

The Church That Kept Being Rebuilt

The fabric around you is a palimpsest, and it repays a close reading. A church has stood on this site since at least the early medieval period, roughly the eleven hundreds, when this riverside parish grew prosperous on the wine and fish trades. It was enlarged and altered over the centuries in the usual organic way, including a new south aisle added in the late fourteenth century.

The Great Fire of 1666 gutted it, but the parish chose repair over replacement, patching the medieval shell and, crucially, commissioning Christopher Wren for an entirely new tower and steeple between about sixteen ninety-five and seventeen oh one. That steeple is the reason architectural historians care about this ruin. Wren crowned a square tower with a slender needle spire carried on four flying arches springing inward from the corners, a Gothic silhouette from the great classicist, and daring enough that people fully expected it to blow down. It didn't, and the tower you see is genuine Wren, the oldest surviving element on the site.

The third act is the one visitors almost never know. By the early nineteenth century the fire-damaged, much-patched body of the church had become structurally unsound, and in eighteen seventeen it was largely demolished, Wren's tower excepted, and rebuilt to a new design by David Laing, then architect to the Board of Customs, assisted by the young William Tite. Laing worked in the Perpendicular Gothic style, and it is his elegant traceried windows and wall-lines, reopened for worship in eighteen twenty-one, that give the ruin its present shape. So the garden's romantic outline is essentially Regency Gothic revival, wrapped around a genuine seventeenth-century Wren tower.

Keep that layering in mind as you look. The tower is roughly three hundred and thirty years old and belongs to Wren's Baroque age. The nave walls are two hundred years old and belong to the Gothic revival. The medieval church that actually stood through the Fire is gone entirely, remembered only in the dedication and the ground beneath your feet.

It is a useful corrective to the comfortable idea that old buildings are single, fixed, settled things. This one was demolished and remade at least three times by people each convinced they were building for the ages, and each time the city simply moved on and rebuilt again. What finally stopped the cycle was not another architect, but a war.

The Last Night of the Blitz, and the Ruin as Amenity

The wound that made this garden was inflicted on a precise and terrible night. Through the winter of nineteen forty and into nineteen forty-one, the Luftwaffe bombed London after dark in the campaign known as the Blitz. The raid of the tenth to eleventh of May, nineteen forty-one, was the single most destructive of the entire assault: well over five hundred aircraft, a bright moonlit night, and a low tide on the Thames that starved the fire hoses of water. By dawn thousands were dead and much of the city was ablaze. That was the night St Dunstan's was gutted. Incendiaries and blast took the roof and the nave and blew out the windows, leaving only the outer walls and, once again, Wren's tower standing.

There is a grim neatness to the timing. That May raid proved to be the last major attack of the Blitz. Within weeks Hitler turned east to invade the Soviet Union, and the sustained night bombing of London essentially stopped. So this church absorbed one of the closing, heaviest blows of the whole campaign.

Afterwards the Church of England faced a surplus of ruins across the City and a reorganisation that meant many would never be rebuilt. St Dunstan's was one of them, and here the story takes its distinctive turn. In nineteen sixty-seven the City of London Corporation resolved not to reconstruct the church but to lay out a public garden within its shell, which opened in nineteen seventy-one. It was, quietly, a piece of conservation philosophy: the ruin would be kept as a ruin, stabilised and planted rather than restored away, its damage preserved as memory.

The planting was inspired. Climbers, winter-flowering shrubs and trees were set so that greenery spills through the Gothic tracery and a canopy closes over the roofless nave, with a low fountain at the centre. The high walls create a genuine sheltered microclimate, a windless pocket that lets tender plants flourish, and it draws office workers at lunchtime and, these days, a steady stream of photographers and film crews. It has hosted weddings and fashion shoots, and it is protected at the highest grade.

What you are standing in, then, is a deliberate paradox: a building destroyed by war and consciously never healed, whose very brokenness has become its beauty and its purpose. Most bomb sites were cleared and forgotten. This one was kept open, more or less as the fire left it, and handed over to the trees.

St Paul's: Wren's Second City

St Paul's is the fifth cathedral on this site; its predecessor, Old St Paul's, was one of the longest churches in Europe when the Great Fire consumed it in 1666. The rebuilding gave Christopher Wren — Oxford astronomer turned architect — the commission of the millennium, and the politics were as hard as the engineering: his preferred radical designs were rejected, and the approved “Warrant Design” included a clause allowing “ornamental” changes, which Wren stretched to the breaking point, quietly evolving the design toward the triple-shelled dome you see. The inner dome, a brick cone bearing the lantern's weight, and the outer timber-and-lead dome are three separate structures — the visible silhouette is essentially theatrical. Completed in 1710, it was declared officially finished in Wren's lifetime; he's buried in the crypt under the epitaph “Lector, si monumentum requiris, circumspice” — reader, if you seek his monument, look around you. The crypt also holds Nelson, in a coffin made from the mast of a French ship, and Wellington. The Second World War sealed the building's symbolic status: Churchill's directive that St Paul's be saved at all costs, the volunteer St Paul's Watch patrolling the roofs, and Herbert Mason's photograph of the dome above the smoke of the twenty-ninth of December, 1940 — probably the most famous British image of the war.

The Climb, the Whisper, and Thornhill's Ceiling

The ascent of the dome is one of London's great experiences, and it rewards knowing what you are looking at. The first stage, two hundred and fifty-seven steps up a spiral stair, brings you to the Whispering Gallery, the walkway encircling the base of the inner dome. Its party trick is genuine and worth doing: a whisper aimed at the wall on one side is audible clear across the gallery, because the sound clings to the smooth concave surface and travels around the circumference rather than crossing the void. The effect was described scientifically by the physicist Lord Rayleigh, who studied it here and published his analysis in eighteen seventy-eight, and it gave its name to a whole class of physics, the whispering-gallery waves, which turn up today in lasers and tiny optical sensors. You are standing, in other words, inside the original of a phenomenon that now lives in laboratories.

From the gallery, look up into the dome. The eight great monochrome scenes from the life of Saint Paul were painted by Sir James Thornhill between about seventeen fifteen and seventeen nineteen. He worked in grisaille, shades of grey and brown rather than full colour, and did so deliberately, so that from the floor the figures read as carved relief in harmony with Wren's stonework rather than shouting over it. Thornhill won the commission partly on patriotic grounds, an English Protestant preferred over the fashionable foreign painters of the day, and he was reputedly paid by the square yard.

Above the Whispering Gallery the climb continues into open air. The Stone Gallery, at the base of the outer dome, comes at three hundred and seventy-eight steps and gives you the balustraded terrace view over the City. The truly determined press on up the narrowing space between the dome's shells to the Golden Gallery, five hundred and twenty-eight steps from the cathedral floor and around eighty-five metres up, encircling the base of the lantern.

Recall the structural sleight of hand from the base story, the hidden brick cone between the inner and outer domes. This climb is where you feel it, because much of the upper ascent runs through the tapering gap around that cone, the invisible spine that carries the stone lantern overhead. The genius of the thing is that the silhouette you admire from the street, the one Diana's carriage rolled toward, is essentially a lightweight timber and lead shell, while the real load is borne by a cone of brick you never quite see, and climb straight past on your way to the top.

The Delayed-Action Bomb of 1940

The base story gave you the icons of the cathedral's war, Churchill's order that it be saved at all costs and Herbert Mason's photograph of the dome above the smoke. Here is the episode that came first and mattered just as much. On the night of the eighth to ninth of September nineteen forty, in the opening days of the Blitz, a large German bomb fell beside the south-west tower near the west front, and failed to explode. It had bored some twenty-seven feet into the ground, and it was a delayed-action device, fitted with a timer fuse that could detonate at any moment. Where it lay, it was reckoned capable of bringing down the entire west end of St Paul's.

The task of removing it fell to a bomb-disposal section of the Royal Engineers under a temporary lieutenant named Robert Davies. Digging it out took three days of extraordinary nerve. The bomb had fractured a gas main, and the shaft caught fire more than once, forcing the sappers back out. When they finally exposed and lifted it, Davies had the bomb loaded onto a lorry and drove it himself through cleared streets to Hackney Marshes in the east of London, where it was detonated in the open. The blast tore a crater around a hundred feet across, a vivid measure of what had been ticking beside the cathedral.

Davies, along with Sapper George Wylie, who had worked in the excavation, was awarded the George Cross. The decoration had only just been instituted by King George the Sixth, and these were among the very first ever conferred, the second and third by most accounts. It is one of the odd footnotes of the story that Davies was later disgraced in an unrelated fraud case, but nothing diminishes what the section achieved in those three days.

The point is worth holding onto as you stand here. The survival of St Paul's through the Second World War is usually told as a matter of firewatchers on the roof and one miraculous photograph, and both are real. But the cathedral's closest brush with destruction came not from fire but from a single buried bomb in the second week of the Blitz, and it was averted by unglamorous, methodical courage: men digging downward toward a fuse that might have killed them all, and then a slow drive across London with the thing riding on the back of a truck.

The Nation's Stage, and the Geometric Staircase

If Westminster Abbey is where England crowns and buries its monarchs, St Paul's is where the nation gathers for its other great occasions, and the guest lists read like modern history. Winston Churchill's state funeral was held here on the thirtieth of January nineteen sixty-five, a rare state funeral for a commoner, attended by representatives of more than a hundred countries. In one of the era's indelible images, as his coffin travelled up the Thames afterward, the crane jibs along the wharves dipped in salute. The cathedral has also hosted the Jubilee thanksgivings of monarchs from Victoria through George the Fifth to Elizabeth the Second, whose Golden and Diamond Jubilee services were held beneath this dome.

And of course the wedding. On the twenty-ninth of July nineteen eighty-one, Charles married Lady Diana Spencer here before a congregation of three and a half thousand and a global television audience estimated at up to seven hundred and fifty million. They chose St Paul's over the traditional royal venue of Westminster Abbey precisely because it seated more guests and offered a longer, grander processional route through the City. Diana's ivory silk taffeta gown had a train of nearly eight metres, so long it emerged from the glass coach visibly creased, and it became the most dissected dress of its generation.

There is a quieter marvel to seek out, in the south-west tower: the Dean's Staircase, better known as the Geometric Staircase. It is a self-supporting spiral of stone, each cantilevered tread resting on the one below and anchored into the wall, so that it appears to climb upward with no central support at all. It is a bravura demonstration of Wren-era engineering, and it has enjoyed a delightful second life on screen. This is the staircase that stands in for the Divination Tower at Hogwarts in Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban, and it has appeared in other films besides. Millions who have never set foot in London have

watched actors climb it without knowing it belongs to Wren's cathedral.

Put the two halves together and you have the essence of the building's civic role. It is at once the solemn theatre where the country stages its grief and its celebration, funerals and weddings and jubilees under Thornhill's dome, and a working prop in the wider culture, its stones lent out to the movies. For a cathedral conceived as a monument to permanence after the Fire, it has proved remarkably good at staying at the centre of national life, whatever the century throws at it.